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## Introduction

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I believe in a fundamental and universal truth: *Trauma blocks love and connection*, and healing our wounds provides access to the love and goodness that is inherent in us all. I further believe we each possess internal wisdom—an inner compass, a truth in feeling—and when we’re connected to these inner resources, we are in alignment and can live our best authentic life. Trauma violates this connection within us and disrupts our ability to bond freely with others. For the sake of survival, we disengage from ourselves, lose connection to that which is true, avoid vulnerability, and shun communion with those around us. Our job as Internal Family Systems (IFS) therapists is to help our clients confront, come to terms with, and release the pain and anguish they carry from past experiences. The healing process enables our clients to reconnect naturally and organically to their inner virtues, allowing them to reclaim self-connection, experience self-love, transcend their trauma, and exercise the ability to unite with and love others.

### THE PURPOSE OF THIS BOOK

As someone with a trauma history, it’s not surprising that I’ve spent most of my career helping clients who struggle with multiple forms of abuse. I was extremely fortunate to be able to collaborate with and espouse the teachings of Bessel van der Kolk over the last 29 years. This true visionary has consistently pushed traditional treatment boundaries to support, promote, and study new and innovative treatments for sufferers of the unspeakable.

I met Dick Schwartz, the founder of the IFS model, at one of Bessel’s annual trauma conferences, and we instantly bonded. There was an energy running through my body that felt extraordinary to me and larger than the both of us. Dick said: “Can you feel that Frank?” I did, and I instinctively knew in that moment that I was there to be of assistance to him on his journey. I’m in awe of Dick’s tireless ambition to share the truths about IFS around the world and am forever grateful to him for including me on this adventure. This experience has been personally life changing, positioning me to better understand myself and to more effectively support my clients. I am a firm believer in IFS—convinced that it offers the most comprehensive approach for healing complex and dissociative trauma. IFS is also a paradigm for living: Those exposed to it live more consciously and choose to be more self-connected and openly compassionate.

My hope in writing this book is to help clinicians overcome the common pitfalls and roadblocks frequently associated with treating complex post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) or relational trauma by using the IFS model of therapy. Equipped with this knowledge and approach, you can help your clients learn how to effectively embrace, validate, and support the positive intentions of all the extreme symptoms that accompany their trauma. You can also learn to identify and gently be with the parts of you that get activated when working with your clients so you can more efficiently access and mend the wounds that plague them.

This book will explore the different types of trauma, examine the ways IFS is different from traditional phase-oriented treatment, demonstrate how to incorporate IFS with other models of treatment, and address protective parts in a trauma-specific manner so your clients can unlock access to the wounds they protect. Together, we will incorporate neuroscience knowledge as it relates to the IFS model and review the neurobiology of PTSD and dissociation. Additionally, we will investigate how neuroscience can inform therapeutic decisions with extreme symptoms and will discover the unique ways in which IFS addresses attachment trauma. We will delve into neglect, vulnerability, shame, and common adaptations associated with relational trauma as it relates to various parts, such as those that are critical, numbing, avoidant, passive, perpetrating, substance using, and caretaking.

What's more, we will review a range of wounds and the different types of unburdening practices associated with complex and extreme trauma. We will also cover common roadblocks to healing and discuss ways to successfully overcome them so your clients can effectively release the pain they carry. This book will incorporate case examples, personal experiences, and clinical exercises to enhance your learning as well.

Whenever I present neuroscience knowledge that I feel is relevant to the IFS model, be aware that this is only my perspective, and as IFS research evolves, we will have a more definitive explanation of how IFS therapy affects the brain and the nervous system. In recent years, our field has expanded and greatly benefitted from discoveries about the connection between neuroscience and psychotherapy. Psychotherapy has gained a new level of legitimacy within the scientific and medical community, as we are no longer seen as a "soft science." As scientific knowledge continues to explain what is occurring neurologically throughout the psychotherapeutic process, we can better use this knowledge to inform our therapeutic decision-making and continue to advance our capacity for healing overwhelming life experiences.

Ultimately, my wish as a psychiatrist, therapist, and trauma survivor is that this book will offer you a unique perspective on how to transcend relational trauma by using IFS. Welcome, and thanks for joining me on this exciting journey, which I hope will be informative, valuable, and rewarding.